

ORION (CONT'D)

I'm sorry. Is everyone following?
(beat)
Questions?

ROMAN

Yeah, who am I play—

ORION

The partner, Rainer. Silas...
you'll be reading for Edward.
Ophelia, you'll read the action.
Good?

ALL

Good.

ORION

Great. Shall we read?

They all open to page one. Ophelia is still looking for a script. Slightly annoyed, Orion hands her a copy tucked under his own. She looks around for a spot. There isn't one. She quickly grabs a chair from inside the house and sits it next to Orion. She and Orion whisper to one another.

OPHELIA

Sorry, I—

ORION

I sent you the pdf in advance.

OPHELIA

I didn't know—

ORION

It's fine. Just think next time.

OPHELIA

(trying not to take
offense)

Right. Of course.

(opens the script)

As Ophelia reads, we slowly zoom into the script and sit on the page to read along with her.

OPHELIA (CONT'D)

Interior. Rainer's bedroom.
Midnight. A cascade of adventure.
Memorabilia lines every open space.
Posters plaster the walls in a
tasteful manner.

(MORE)

OPHELIA (CONT'D)

He proudly presents Star Wars on the wall and the TV. A piano sits in the corner.

As Silas speaks, WE PAN OUT OF THE SCRIPT and are transported to Rainer's bedroom.

INT. RAINER'S (ORION'S) BEDROOM - MIDNIGHT (CONTINUOUS)

Orion sits on the bed as Roman and Silas now perform the script off-book.

SILAS

He's everything I'm not. Strong. Faithful. Confident and cocky. Enticing. Silly. He wants you to look at him like a god but he's too humble to have you worship him. He's got an insatiable desire to attract others. I beg for anything he's willing to offer. A look, a stare, a hand on my head, or a hug for my soul. I shave my head before I meet him in an effort to be anything but myself.

ORION

(breaking the script)
We'll have to shave your head, Silas. I hope that's okay.
(not waiting)
Roman?

ROMAN

You look... different. Like a blank canvas.

SILAS

You're an artist, so paint me.

ROMAN

I write music.

SILAS

Then write songs about us.

ROMAN

Well, I'll need a story to tell. Say something. Anything! Tell me all the good things you think about me.

SILAS

Once, when I was twenty-one, I loved. I went over to a boy's to watch a movie because I was drinking and courageous, and he was presumably...

ROMAN

Lonely.

SILAS

I on the other hand was always lonely. He had no clue. He was unaware of what it was like for no one to take an interest in you or believe in your truths. Yet he fawned over things about me that I could care less for.

ROMAN

You write.

SILAS

So do you.

ROMAN

You're courageous.

SILAS

You believe in God but bleed with men.

ROMAN

I lack luster.

SILAS

You shine and turn everything to gold.

Roman moves closer to Silas. His face is dangerously close to his, but out of kindness, not romance.

ROMAN

Tell me about the boy.

SILAS

The way I remember it, he ran these massive hands over my buzzed head.

Roman runs his hand over Silas' head in awe of his hair, or lack thereof.

ROMAN

Massive in what way?

SILAS

Massive in the way that a man is strong.

ROMAN

And strong?

SILAS

Strong in the way that I wished I was. He spoke with a cool confidence.

ROMAN

Confident in what kind of manner?

SILAS

He was full of himself, self-obsessed, narcissistic— or maybe I was. He only indulged in me when it best suited him. He only invited me in when it served a purpose.

ROMAN

Have I shown you my room?

SILAS

Never.

ROMAN

Can I?

SILAS

Of course. He shows me the lion's den. I'm blinded by the darkness. His bed is made up with a heavy blanket on the end, more than one sleeping pillow, and a single throw pillow. I'm ashamed of myself.

ROMAN

Why are you ashamed?

SILAS

I think about this the boys that have been in his bed before me. A clip of jealousy ignites my pilot light and boils my blood. My heart rate picks up.

WE HEAR the heartbeat pound in our ears.

SILAS (CONT'D)

This is the same place he did those things with them, among other things. I've heard his stories. His ponderings and misdoings. I'm afraid he won't offer the same to me one day.

ROMAN

It's imperative to write the story, before the story writes you.

ORION

It's imperative to write the story, before the story writes you.

SILAS

I imagine him stacking the pillows, but the images of him with others are fuzzy and blurred. They're fast and distant. My mind wanders and I wonder how he sleeps. I wonder if I'm going to be a burden to that cycle.

ROMAN

Follow me. I want to hear everything you've got to say.

Roman does this as Silas speaks.

SILAS

He clambers up onto the bed and leans up against the wall, one leg straight out, the other tucked under his thigh. His calves are thick with dedication. It looks like he's never shaved his legs a day in his life. I know mine are naked and bare and probably too feminine for him, because/

ROMAN

I live with a gay man and a homophobic man. I wear maroon almost daily.

SILAS

A color synonymous with masculinity and dignity around here. He detests the idea of queerness.

(pause)

So do I.

(beat)

I should stop.

ROMAN

You don't have to.

SILAS

It's my story to tell, not yours.
You asked me to come over to watch
a movie.

ROMAN

Yeah, but I'd rather watch you. Go
on. I'll care for your story. I'll
laugh at the good parts.

SILAS

And the bad parts?

ROMAN

I'll write them down in a way that
makes everyone understand you. I'm
really good at knowing how to make
people care.

SILAS

He's confident and cocky and sure
of his art in the best of ways. His
words wash over his lips with the
same power waves are built upon.
He's potent. He poisons my blood
and demands I find a new faith in
men. In him. He's kind— in a sort
of way that most people aren't.

ROMAN

How so?

SILAS

He leans forward and listens, his
eyes wild with interest. He makes
me believe he has exponential
stakes in the words I say, however
external he might be.

ROMAN

He goes for your leg and makes his
way up to the thigh. He grasps you,
his hand covering your flesh
entirely.

SILAS

But it ends as quickly as it
begins. His grip slackens. His
fingers disappear.

INT. RAINER'S BATHROOM - CONTINUOUS

Roman goes to brush his teeth under a humming blue light.

ROMAN

You should stay over. You're staying over right? I wanna hear the rest of this.

SILAS

Yeah... I can stay. I'd like that if you want me to.

ROMAN

You can sleep in as long as you need. The room stays pitch black.

SILAS

It's like a lion's den in here.

ROMAN (CONT'D)

It's like a lion's den in here.

ROMAN (CONT'D)

I have to get up at six, but I would like for you to stay.

SILAS

No, I can get up with you. I can get a head start on my day.

ROMAN

So, you'll stay.

SILAS

So, I stay. We talk like two friends who have known each other since the first dawn. Over the hours, I learn nothing about his life but everything about him.

ROMAN

We should write something together. Do you know piano? Of course you don't but I'll show you. Something that says I love you. Even if we don't know how we feel yet.

CU on bare piano keys. Two sets of hands appear. One carefully glides into place on top of the keys. The other is fast and has poor posture. The graceful pair begins to play and as they do the music continues and we...

FADE TO BLACK.